

CATS

Members of the cat family, or Felidae, are among the most specialized of meat-eaters, and many species consume no vegetable material at all. As a group, cats are supremely athletic, having a supple, muscular body that is well adapted to running, climbing, leaping, and swimming. Their short jaws contain sharp teeth adapted for stabbing (canines) and slicing (carnassials). They have retractile claws.

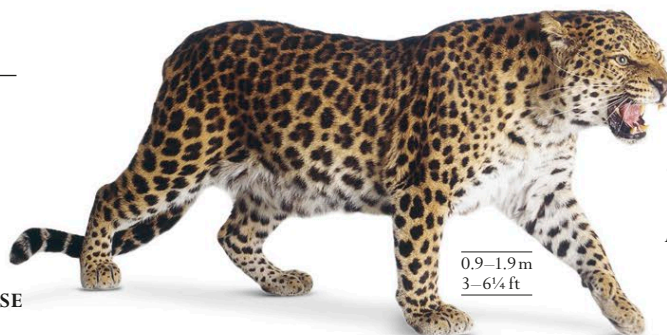


67–107 cm
26–42 in

INDOCHINESE CLOUDED LEOPARD

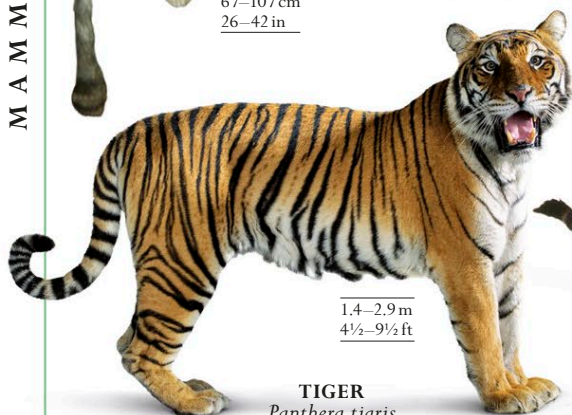
Neofelis nebulosa

A large, nocturnal, S.E. Asian forest cat with cloud-shaped coat markings, this species is declining due to hunting and habitat loss.



0.9–1.9 m
3–6¼ ft

LEOPARD
Panthera pardus
This most adaptable of the big cats occurs widely throughout Africa and southern Asia. It often hides its prey in trees, away from other hunters.



1.4–2.9 m
4½–9½ ft

TIGER

Panthera tigris

The world's largest cat hunts using stealth and raw power to take prey as large as oxen. Fewer than 3,900 remain in the wild in Asia.

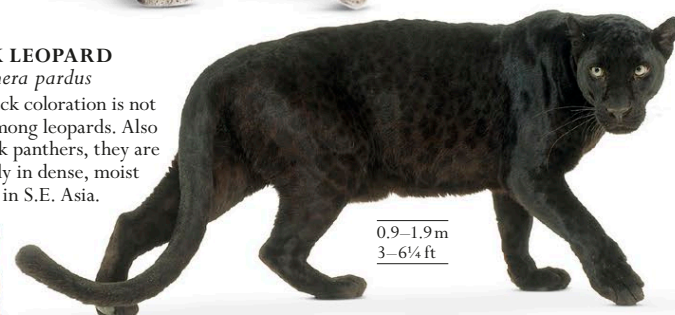


1.2–1.7 m
4–5½ ft

JAGUAR

Panthera onca

The America's only big cat, the jaguar is an excellent climber and swimmer. Its broad prey base includes deer, turtles, and fish.



0.9–1.9 m
3–6¼ ft

BLACK LEOPARD

Panthera pardus

Melanistic black coloration is not uncommon among leopards. Also known as black panthers, they are found mainly in dense, moist forests in S.E. Asia.



thick mane

♂

♀

1.6–2.5 m
5¼–8¼ ft

LION

Panthera leo

Africa's top predator lives in family groups known as prides. Females work together to bring down prey including zebra and antelope.